

The conscription of women into the British Army was legalized in 1941



IN BRIEF

A GREATER WAR

The sheer scale of World War II was unprecedented; the nature of its warfare meant that more women were in harm's way than in any previous conflict.

1939

December The women's section of the British organization of the Air Transport Auxiliary is founded.

1941

July 2 Canada's Women's Army Corps is created.

October Josef Stalin orders the creation of all-female air force units in Russia.

December British government passes the National Service Act, which allows conscription of some women into war work or armed forces.

1942

May 14 Congress approves the creation of the Women's Army Auxiliary Corps, which begins active duty as the Women's Army Corps in July 1943.

July 21 Congress approves the creation of the Women Accepted for Volunteer Emergency Service, a female branch of the Naval Reserve.

1943

February 22 Sophie Scholl is executed in Munich for her resistance against the Nazis.

August 5 The Women Airforce Service Pilots organization is formally founded in the US.

1945

April Princess Elizabeth (later Queen Elizabeth II) trains in the Auxiliary Territorial Service (ATS); as 2nd Lieutenant Elizabeth Windsor, she serves as a mechanic and driver for the ATS.

◀ **ON PARADE** THE US WOMEN'S ARMY CORPS WEAR GAS MASKS AT A DRILL, FLORIDA, 1942.

